



Language origins

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Homo Ludens

The Yale School of Art provides the entire book by J Huizinga online for free, for your reading pleasure. <https://digit.in/jul20-52>

The origins of Culture

Human culture is older than humans

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I

Imagine a tiny wormhole opens up and transports you to the middle of a jungle in the paleolithic.

You might have some idea on how to build a fire, or the theory of making stone tools and possibly might seek out a river for water, then find a cave for shelter. However, you would have a hard time surviving without the direct knowledge and experience of these things. Your understanding of how to manage permissions of people in a Telegram group or how you troubleshoot a problematic WiFi connection will have no value at that time. You would need to understand the topology of the land, know which kind of mushrooms are poisonous, the migration patterns of herbivores, the cycle of the seasons, and wayfinding using the stars as some of the essential survival skills. When it comes to tools, you would need to know to make a hand axe, or a spear. The creation of pots, smelting metals or building boats would all take years of learning. Also, you would have a hard time communicating with any humans that you may run into. A child born during that time, would



not have come into the world with all this knowledge, they would have to learn it from the elders around them. This was human culture in its primitive form, and it was older than humans. Neanderthals and Homo Erectus both made crude tools and knew how to wield fire. There is evidence that even older branches of the Homo family tree, including Australopithecus and Homo habilis may be tool users. When anatomically modern humans came out of Africa around 90,000 years ago, they already had a cultural heritage. It was during the time period of the last glacial period, between 50,000 years to 10,000 years ago, that the human culture really blossomed.

TOOLS AND ART

Since the stone age, man began fashioning increasingly intricate and purpose built tools. After learning to chip stones, a major development was hafting, which involves attaching bone or stone points to wooding shafts. The carving of bones to make weapons such as harpoons eventually led to some humans carving figurines out of ivory, some of the earliest examples of art that we have. Then of course, there were the cave paintings. We do not know what function the paintings in the deep recesses of caves that humans lived in, actually served. Maybe before a hunt, people would pray in front of these drawings of animals for luck. Maybe they were